

States **ORISSA**

| By Farzand Ahmed |

Orissa Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik is the invisible man who has managed to retain his popularity for two terms despite serious law and order problems and obstacles to investment. If his Government, as it seems, gets a record third term, it will mean his ministers have been awfully busy at their desks. It turns out they have, but for all the wrong reasons. Instead of development, the Orissa Government has gone memo-crazy, spending more time in recommending transfers and promotions than in actual governance.

It has come to light that five ministers holding key portfolios sent out a total of 1,852 written recommendations for transfers and postings between April 1, 2005 and June 16, 2008. The information has been supplied by the ministries concerned. The cabinet ministers who recommended transfers and postings include Prafulla Chandra Ghadai (finance), Raghunath Mohanty (panchayati raj and parliamentary affairs), Debi Mishra (excise and tourism), Suryo Patro (energy, IT and culture) and A.U. Singhdeo (works and housing). All are Biju Janata Dal (BJD) ministers and considered to be close to the chief minister.

The information, obtained under a Right to Information (RTI) request filed by Biswajit Mohanty, a Cuttack-based social activist and member of Transparency International, showed that the transfers/postings splurge amounted to a veritable private industry flourishing under the very nose of 'Mr Clean', the chief minister. The documents showed that transfers/postings were recommended for primary schoolteachers, junior clerks, supervisors, auxiliary nurse midwives, laboratory technicians and police sepoy in clear violation of government rules and very obviously for dubious reasons.

Raghunath, a senior BJD leader, had shot off 877 letters while Mishra was close behind with 318 memos. Naveen's Doon School buddy Singhdeo kept the transfer industry buzzing with 283 letters. Patro sent out 255 letters



PATNAIK (CENTRE) AT A BJD MEET IN BHUBANESHWAR

The Memo MINISTERS

While Naveen Patnaik talked of industrialisation, some of his ministers ran a transfer-posting industry instead of working for the development of the poorest state

while Ghadai, who claims to have brought about a fiscal turnaround in the state, recommended 119 transfers and postings. The ministers recommended the transfers of employees in departments other than their own.

According to the revelations, Mishra, who heads the Excise Department, recommended the trans-

fer of the headmaster of Karadapada primary school in Angul to Jalakeli primary school of Narsinghpur in Cuttack district to the Education Department. The excuse was: "He has some genuine family problems." He also recommended to the engineer-in-chief of the Water Resources Department that a junior engineer (irrigation),